

Argos and the Lost Keepsake

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

After all the long years on these shores, the ships were nearly ready at last. The whole Ship Camp hummed with happy work: sails were being patched, baskets of figs lashed down, and everyone talking of home across the wine-dark sea. The hardest day was nearly over, and a soft, glad feeling drifted along the beach with the smoke of the cook-fires.

But by one tent sat your friend Lykos, with his head in his hands. He was not hurt, and nobody had been unkind to him. He had simply lost something, and his heart was heavy with it.

"My keepsake is gone," he said when you knelt beside him. "A little token, carved from olive wood, that my grandmother pressed into my hand the morning we set sail. I have carried it all this long way, and now I have dropped it somewhere out on the windswept shore. We sail at sunset. I cannot go home and leave it behind. I just cannot."

Odysseus the Bright, captain of the seafarers, came and crouched down with you. He was the sort of man who would rather solve a problem than shout about it. "So," he said gently, "a friend is sad, and a small treasure is lost on a very long beach. That is no job for spears. That is a job for bright ideas and a faithful heart. Will you go and find it before the tide and the wind hide it for good?"

Into your hands he gave three gifts: the Conch Horn, a great spiral shell that sounds a warm calling note across the water; the Basket of Honey and Figs, in case the search grew long; and Penelope's Thread, a ball of strong weaving thread to mark your way so you could never lose it. Then he put two fingers to his lips and whistled, and up the beach, at a stiff old trot, came a grey-muzzled hound with bright, kind eyes and a tail that would not stop.

"This is Argos the Faithful Hound," said Odysseus, scratching the dog's ears. "He never forgets a friend, and he never forgets a scent. Follow his nose. Follow one another. And whatever you do, leave no one behind."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1 Following Argos

Argos lowered his nose to the sand and set off, and you went after him along the shining edge of the sea. He did not hurry. Every few steps he stopped at some small mark, breathed it in, and glanced back to see that you were watching too.

The beach was written all over with clues, if you only looked. Here was a footprint pressing deep where someone had stood thinking. Here was a fig, dropped and forgotten. Here was a wide scuff in the sand where a tired traveller had sat down to rest, and beyond it the footprints carried on in one clear direction.



Which way did your friend walk? Will you crouch with Argos and read the tracks together, telling the marks that lead onward from the marks that lead nowhere? Argos will tell you if you are warm.

When you chose the trail the clues pointed to, Argos gave a single bright bark, as if to say yes, *that is it*, and trotted on with his tail high. The scent was yours now, and the search had truly begun.

Stop 2 The Tide Pools

The trail led you in among the tide pools, those sunlit little ponds the sea leaves behind on the rocks, each one bright with shells and darting crabs. Somewhere here your friend had stopped, and the keepsake had brushed past the lip of one pool. But there were three of them, and they all glittered the same in the sun.

Beside the first pool lay a single white shell. Beside the second lay a striped shell, brown and cream. Beside the third lay a smooth grey pebble, round as an egg.

Argos snuffled carefully all along the rocks, then sat and looked at you, and you understood that he had found two clues for you to hold in your heads. The scent, he seemed to say, had passed a striped shell, and not a white one. And the scent had not lingered where the grey pebble lay.



Can you keep both clues in mind at once? Not the white-shell pool, because the scent passed a striped shell. Not the pebble pool, because the scent did not stop there. So which pool is left? That is where your friend sat down to rest, and where a loose thread slipped from the hem of his cloak.

When you pointed to the second pool, the one with the striped shell and no pebble, there it was: a thread of wool snagged on a rock, lying like a little arrow that pointed on along the shore. Argos thumped his tail against the sand. *Well thought*, his bright eyes said. *Well remembered*.

Stop 3 The Far Dune

On and on the trail went, until the ships were small behind you, and it ended at a lonely dune where the wind had been busy all the long afternoon, lifting the pale sand and letting it fall. If the keepsake had dropped here, the wind had spent hours tucking it out of sight.

Argos cast about in slow, careful circles, his nose low, until all at once he stopped quite still, one paw lifted, his ears pricked up, and stared down at a single patch of sand as if he could see straight through it.



Will you trust his faithful nose? Will you kneel where he points and dig, gently and together, brushing the loose sand aside a handful at a time, watching for one warm corner of olive wood?

You swept the sand away, and there it was, a glint of carved wood waking in the sunlight. Argos finished the job himself, scooping the last of the sand free with one soft, careful paw, and then he lifted the little token up in his mouth as proud as anything and laid it, warm and

whole, into your waiting hands.

Nobody Left Behind

You ran back along the shore with the keepsake held close and safe, the ships growing tall again ahead, Argos bounding beside you with his ears flying. And when Lykos looked up and saw what you carried, his whole face opened like the morning.

"You found it," he whispered, and then he was laughing and crying at once. "You came all that way back for it. You came back for *me*." He cradled the little olive-wood token, and then he threw his arms around Argos, who wagged so mightily he nearly toppled them both into the sand.

Odysseus the Bright watched, and there was something soft in his bright face. "A strong arm could not have done this," he said. "Only faithful hearts that would not leave a friend behind. That is the best idea there ever was, and you have it." And far out where the bright waves rolled, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifted her gentle face from the water and smiled upon you, and the sea lay calm and kind for the voyage ahead.

So the ships sailed home at sunset with every friend aboard and every treasure safe, and not one single thing, and not one single soul, was left behind on the windswept shore. Well done, heroes. Well done, good Argos. You kept faith, and you came home together.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle, kindly tale: there is no fight in it at all, only a lost treasure, a sad friend, and a faithful dog to help you put things right.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Loyalty** (standing by a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any seashell for the Conch Horn, a small cake or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On these shores, no hero stands alone, and that is the whole heart of this tale.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.
2	You find your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind off the sea, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this story and no fight to win. The challenge is simply to keep faith with a friend: to follow Argos, read the clues, remember carefully, and not give up until the lost keepsake is found and carried home. Let the reunion land, the friend overjoyed, Argos praised, Thetis the Sea-Mother smiling on the calm sea; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three stops and their solutions.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and loyalty over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Following Argos (Easy)

The challenge. Argos has the scent, but the players must read the tracks and clues along the shore to choose which way their friend walked. Some marks lead onward; some lead nowhere.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Observation and Loyalty. Have the children look closely with Argos and sort the clues: the footprints that carry on in one clear direction, the dropped fig and the resting scuff that sit along that same line, against any stray marks that double back or peter out. Following the clues that agree with one another, and trusting Argos when he barks happily, sends them the right way. Any child who slows down, looks carefully, and stays on the trail has solved it.

Fallback. If they are unsure, let Argos take a few steps the right way and look back, or let them spend an energy star to "look again" and notice that the deep, onward footprints all point the same way. Sticking close to the dog and not giving up always finds the trail; this stop is meant to feel like an easy, happy start.

Stop 2: The Tide Pools (Normal)

The challenge. The trail leads in among three sunlit tide pools, and the players must work out which pool their friend rested beside, where a thread slipped from his cloak.

The worked example. Read the scene so the three pools are clear. Beside **pool one** lies a white shell. Beside **pool two** lies a striped shell. Beside **pool three** lies a smooth grey pebble. Argos gives two clues to hold in mind at once: the scent **passed a striped shell** (so not the white-shell pool), and the scent **did not stop where the pebble was** (so not the pebble pool). Cross off pool one and pool three, and only **pool two**, the striped-shell pool with no pebble, is left. That is where the dropped thread is found, pointing the way on.

Intended solution. This is a Memory, Logic and Observation moment. The bright move is to remember both of Argos's clues and use them to rule pools out one at a time until a single pool remains. Counting on fingers, pointing at each pool in turn, or laying a token by each one as they reason are all good.

Fallback. If the children lose the thread of it, simplify to one clue at a time: "Argos says not the white shell, so which pools are left?" then "Argos says not the pebble, so which one is it?" Or let them spend an energy star while Argos sniffs straight to the right pool. Reaching pool two by any route counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Far Dune (Normal)

The challenge. The keepsake has fallen near a lonely dune and the wind has half buried it in the sand. Argos finds the spot; the players must dig it out gently and reunite their friend with it.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Loyalty moment. The bright, kind move is to watch where Argos points his nose, kneel at that exact spot, and dig carefully together, brushing the sand away a little at a time and watching for a corner of olive wood rather than scrabbling and scattering it. When they do, the carved token comes up warm and whole, and Argos frees the last of it with one gentle paw. Patience and care, not force, win the day.

Fallback. If a child digs in the wrong place or grows frustrated, have Argos pad over, sniff once, and start the digging himself right where it should be, so they can join in. Spending an

energy star to "look closer" also reveals the glint of wood. The keepsake is always found; the only question is how tenderly.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the keepsake is carried home, Lykos is overjoyed and hugs both the token and Argos, Odysseus the Bright praises the heroes for leaving no one behind, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles on the calm sea so the ships may sail home with every friend and treasure safe aboard. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.